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FLAMES OF FURY: Every communal riot has a political context

THE RIOT ACT

YEAR	PLACE	VICTIMS
1980	MORADABAD	1,500-2,000 die in Idgah stampede and violence.
1981	BIHARSHARIF	80 die as Muslims and Hindus clash over land.
1984	DELHI	2,733 die in anti-Sikh riots after Indira Gandhi's killing.
1987	MEERUT	350 die in violence that started over killings by PAC.
1989	BHAGALPUR	1,000 die in riots triggered by police atrocities.
1992	MUMBAI	1,788 die in riots related to Babri Masjid demolition.
2002	AHMEDABAD	2,000 die after Karsevaks' coach is burnt at Godhra.

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development. The erstwhile mascot of militant Hindutva has become the brand ambassador of "resurgent" Gujarat, though he is yet to get an invitation to Davos. Smart politics, and it worked. In spite of his democratic mandate, the stigma remains. That is largely because of the "family" reputation: the grotesquery of Gujarat 2002 has been further accentuated by the killers' proud pronouncement of their Parivar values. And his administration failed in containing the post-Godhra fury. Still, BJP can't afford to campaign for the trial of Modi for his "crimes against humanity". The comrades can. Gujarat Unravelling has everything the Indian communist can ask for: the "imperial" arrogance of the oppressor; blood in the dispossessed ghettos; the ransacked ideal of secularism; and the murderous sweep of communalism. Amazingly, such overwhelming credentials have not made Gujarat a cause worthy of a CPI(M) campaign. As bogeyman, George Bush is more appealing than Narendra Modi.

The communists' inexplicable indifference is matched by the tactical silence of the Congress. We all know that Manmohan Singh is a gentleman prime minister, not a vulpine manipulator of power politics. Ideally, he should mark a cultural shift in power. And as a Sikh, he "understands the trauma of being labelled". Well, he said BJP was responsible for "the Holocaust in Gujarat". That was an angry one-liner, and the historical allusion was absolutely misplaced. He may be tempted to say Gestapo next time, but it is unlikely that the dehumanisation in Gujarat will sway the conscience of his government—or of his party. Bad conscience can't be the reason, for remorse has never been a Congress trait. It doesn't mean that others are

more humane. No. The entire political class is guilty of communal crimes. Secularism is a lofty ideal, and a necessary slogan. It is still alive in our civil society because of the decencies of those citizens for whom religion is not a political dispute. Secularism, however flawed it may be, survives in spite of the duplicities of our political parties. It may not have spawned the Nehruvian New Man. It has exposed the neo-Nehruvians on the stump.

There is no communal riot without political motivation; still, there is no payback time for the politician. Moradabad '80, Delhi '84, Bombay '92, and many more before and after them but who are the rioters? Who are there waiting for the judgment day? Who are the condemned? Modi is not alone. In the land without justice, he alone seems to have horns and fangs. The horror of Gujarat 2002 calls for the immediate reactivation of the judicial process, but it should not distract us from the terrifying moral vacuum in our political structure, and the failure of the state that can't ensure justice. We know who authored 9/11, and we know who terrorised London. If we have the political will, we will know a lot more than what a sting operation has exposed. We will have enough suspects to fill an Indian version of Guantanamo.

In the end, the Indian tragedy is political: those who have the power to seek the truth have already abandoned the quest. We have no Vaclav Havel to remind us that the politician with a moral conscience "lives in truth". Gujarat and other infamies of India will remain unpunished as long as the political class is steeped in lies. We are condemned to be repulsed by the pathology of the few who are conned by a hidden camera. Don't we need a more open device to deliver justice?